

Maurya Empire

India's First Pan-Indian Power

From Chanakya's conspiracy to Ashoka's compassion -- an empire that shaped a civilisation

Chandragupta Maurya | Bindusara | Ashoka the Great

SSC CGL | Bank PO | RRB | UPSC Prelims

321 BCE - 185 BCE

321

BCE Empire founded

3

Great emperors

33

Ashoka's Edicts issued

185

BCE Empire ends

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Chapter 1 -- The Fall of the Nandas: How It All Began

The year is 321 BCE. The most powerful empire in India -- the Nanda dynasty of Magadha -- sits on a throne of iron and gold, commanding an army of 200,000 infantry, 20,000 cavalry, 2,000 war elephants, and 2,000 chariots. No force in India has dared challenge them. Then a teenage exile with a brilliant, ruthless teacher walks out of the

forests of Taxila and does the impossible.

That exile was **Chandragupta Maurya**. His teacher was **Kautilya**, also known as Chanakya or Vishnugupta -- perhaps the greatest political strategist in Indian history. Together, they did not just overthrow a dynasty. They created **India's first pan-Indian empire** -- a single political entity stretching from modern Afghanistan to Bengal, from the Himalayas to the Deccan.

The Greek ambassador Megasthenes visited the Maurya court under Chandragupta and wrote 'Indica' -- our single most important external source for Mauryan India. His account describes Pataliputra as the greatest city in the world at that time.

Chapter 2 -- Chandragupta Maurya: The Empire Builder (321-297 BCE)

Chandragupta Maurya's life reads like the greatest underdog story in Indian history. Of uncertain but likely Kshatriya/Vaishya origin, he was reputedly noticed by Chanakya at Taxila (Takshashila) -- the ancient university city -- for his natural leadership. Under Chanakya's tutelage in politics, economics, and military strategy, Chandragupta built a guerrilla army from the northwest frontier tribes and marched on Magadha.

Event	Year	Significance
Meets Chanakya at Taxila	~330 BCE	Chanakya, humiliated by Dhana Nanda, vows to destroy the Nandas. Finds Chandragupta as the perfect instrument.
First failed attempt on Magadha	~326 BCE	Direct frontal attack fails. Chanakya learns the lesson: attack the periphery first, then the capital. Strategy shift.
Encounter with Alexander	326 BCE	Chandragupta reportedly met Alexander's army in the Punjab. This exposure to Macedonian military tactics influenced his own army structure.
Overthrows Dhana Nanda	321 BCE	Captured Pataliputra. Nanda dynasty ends. Maurya dynasty begins. Foundation of India's first empire.
Seleucid War & Treaty	305-303 BCE	Defeated Seleucus I Nicator (Alexander's successor) who tried to reclaim NW India. Treaty: Chandragupta got Afghanistan + Balochistan + parts of Persia. Gave 500 war elephants. Seleucus sent Megasthenes as ambassador.
Abdication	297 BCE	Converted to Jainism under Bhadrabahu. Abdicated in favour of son Bindusara. Moved to Shravanabelagola (Karnataka) where he fasted to death (Sallekhana).

*Seleucid Treaty (305 BCE) -- the most important early Mauryan diplomatic event:
Chandragupta gained: modern Afghanistan, Balochistan, parts of Persia.
Chandragupta gave: 500 war elephants to Seleucus.
Result: Seleucus used these elephants to WIN the Battle of Ipsus (301 BCE).*

Chapter 3 -- Chanakya and the Arthashastra: Blueprint of Power

Kautilya's Arthashastra is one of the most remarkable political texts ever written. Composed around the 4th-3rd century BCE, it is simultaneously a manual of statecraft, economics, military strategy, espionage, law, and foreign policy. It predates Machiavelli's 'The Prince' by 1,800 years and is far more comprehensive. The Arthashastra was

lost for over a millennium and rediscovered in 1905 by R. Shamasastri in a Mysore library -- one of history's great rediscoveries.

Topic Covered	Key Content
Definition of Artha	'Artha' = wealth/material well-being + political power. The science of acquisition and protection of the earth (political economy).
Saptanga Theory (7 elements of state)	Swami (king) + Amatya (ministers) + Janapada (territory/people) + Durga (fortified capital) + Kosha (treasury) + Danda (army/punishment) + Mitra (allies). ALL must be strong for a state to survive.
Mandala Theory (Circle of States)	Your neighbour is your enemy; your neighbour's neighbour is your friend. 12-king circle model. Foundation of Indian realpolitik and foreign policy.
Shadgunya (6 foreign policies)	Sandhi (treaty) + Vighraha (war) + Asana (neutrality) + Yana (marching/aggression) + Samshraya (seeking protection) + Dvaidhibhava (double policy). Use the right policy at the right time.
Espionage system	Elaborate spy network: Samstha (stationary spies) and Sanchari (roaming spies). Used in every walk of life -- ascetics, merchants, poison girls (Vishakanya), entertainers.
Danda (punishment)	Danda (rod of punishment) is the king's most important tool. Without danda, the law of fishes (Matsyanyaya -- big fish eats small fish) prevails.
Economic policy	State control of agriculture, mining, trade, and weights/measures. Detailed taxation system. State welfare for disabled, widows, and orphans.
Rediscovery	Lost for ~1,500 years. Rediscovered in 1905 by R. Shamasastri at the Oriental Research Institute, Mysore. Published 1909. -- Direct MCQ answer.

Chanakya's three names to know: Kautilya (gotra name), Chanakya (father's name = Chanak), Vishnugupta (personal name). All three appear in exam questions. He is also called the 'Indian Machiavelli' though he predates Machiavelli by 1,800 years.

Chapter 4 -- Bindusara: The Forgotten Emperor (297-268 BCE)

Sandwiched between two of history's greatest rulers, Bindusara is the most underrated Maurya emperor. He inherited an already enormous empire from his father and expanded it significantly southward -- a feat that often goes unacknowledged. His court was cosmopolitan, his diplomatic contacts wide, and his empire at its death was the largest in Indian history until that point -- ready-made for his son Ashoka to inherit.

Aspect	Detail
Greek name	Called 'Amitrochates' (Amitraghata = 'slayer of enemies') by Greek sources
Territorial expansion	Extended Maurya empire southward across the Deccan to Karnataka. Son Ashoka served as viceroy of Taxila and later Ujjain under him.
Greek ambassador	Deimachus of Plataea (from Seleucid court) served as ambassador at his court. Earlier, Dionysius was sent by Ptolemy II of Egypt.
Diplomatic exchange	Wrote to Seleucid king Antiochus I requesting sweet wine, dried figs, and a philosopher. Antiochus replied he would send wine and figs but cannot sell a philosopher -- one of history's most charming diplomatic exchanges.
Religion	Associated with the Ajivika sect (a heterodox sect between Buddhism and Jainism, founded by Makkhali Gosala). Also had Brahmanical influences.
Son Ashoka	Ashoka served as viceroy of Taxila (suppressed revolt) and Ujjain. Bindusara reportedly preferred another son (Sushima) as heir -- Ashoka seized the throne after Bindusara's death, possibly by eliminating rivals.

Chapter 5 -- Ashoka the Great: From Warrior to Missionary (268-232 BCE)

History has no shortage of conquerors. But it has very few rulers who, after conquest, looked at the devastation they had caused and *changed*. Ashoka is that rare exception. The Kalinga War of 261 BCE was not just a military victory -- it was the most consequential moral turning point in Indian history, transforming a ruthless emperor into a messenger of peace and compassion whose influence would spread from Greece to Sri Lanka to China.

Event	Year	Significance
Accession to throne	268 BCE	Seized throne after Bindusara's death. Rock Edict XIII later says he had 99 brothers -- likely exaggerated but indicates a bloody succession struggle.
Kalinga War	261 BCE	Conquered Kalinga (modern Odisha). Rock Edict XIII: 100,000 killed, 150,000 deported, many more died of disease. The sight of this carnage shattered Ashoka. He never waged war again.
Conversion to Buddhism	260 BCE	Became an upasaka (lay follower) under monk Upagupta (or Nigrodha per some sources). Did not make Buddhism the state religion -- practiced religious tolerance.
Dhamma policy begins	259 BCE	Launched Dhamma as his governing philosophy -- a moral code applicable to all religions, not just Buddhism.

Pilgrimage to Bodh Gaya	<i>~259 BCE</i>	First of many Dhamma Yatras (religious tours) replacing earlier hunting/pleasure tours (Vihar Yatras). Visited Lumbini -- erected pillar there.
Third Buddhist Council	<i>250 BCE</i>	Convened at Pataliputra under Moggaliputta Tissa. Purified the Sangha. Sent missionaries to 9 regions including Sri Lanka (son Mahinda, daughter Sanghamitra).
Death	<i>232 BCE</i>	Died after 36 years of rule. Immediately, the empire began fragmenting under weak successors.

Rock Edict XIII -- Ashoka's most personal and emotional inscription:

'150,000 people were deported, 100,000 were killed and many times that number perished.'

'Beloved of the Gods feels remorse...considers the loss of even one hundredth part grievous.'

This is the most cited Ashokan edict in all government exams.

Chapter 6 -- Ashoka's Dhamma: A New Philosophy of Governance

Ashoka's **Dhamma** (from Sanskrit 'Dharma') was not simply Buddhism by another name. It was a carefully designed *universal moral code* -- applicable to Buddhists, Hindus, Jains, Greeks, and all others under Mauryan rule. It was the world's first attempt at state-sponsored moral governance. Understanding Dhamma is crucial because exams distinguish between Dhamma (Ashoka's policy) and Buddhism (the religion).

Principle	Content
Non-violence (Ahimsa)	Reduced animal slaughter at royal court. Banned hunting and certain animal sacrifices. Planted medicinal trees and dug wells for animals and humans.
Respect for all religions	Tolerance for all sects -- Brahmanical, Jain, Ajivika, Greek religions. Said all religions share the essentials: self-control, purity of mind, gratitude.
Obedience to parents and elders	Emphasis on family values, respect for teachers and Brahmins, generosity to slaves and servants.
Welfare measures	Roads with shade trees and rest houses every 8 kos. Hospitals for humans AND animals. Wells dug at roadsides. Medical plants cultivated.
Dhamma Mahamattas	New category of officials created specifically to spread Dhamma: visit prisons, care for elderly and destitute, monitor religious tolerance.
Dhamma Yatras	Replaced pleasure tours (Vihar Yatras) with religious pilgrimages to Buddhist sacred sites.
NOT Buddhism	Dhamma did NOT make Buddhism the state religion. Ashoka never ordered conversion. He supported ALL religious institutions financially.

Chapter 7 -- Ashoka's Edicts: The Rock and Pillar Network

Ashoka's edicts are among the most remarkable primary sources in ancient history. Inscribed on **rocks** and **polished stone pillars** across a vast geographic spread -- from Afghanistan to Andhra Pradesh, from Girnar in Gujarat to Dhauli in Odisha -- they represent the world's first government-funded public messaging campaign. They were written in Brahmi, Kharosthi, Aramaic, and Greek -- tailored to local audiences.

Edict Type	Number	Language/Script	Key Locations & Content
Major Rock Edicts	14 in total	Mostly Brahmi; Kharosthi in NW; Aramaic/Greek in Afghanistan	Girnar (Gujarat), Shahbazgarhi (NWFP), Mansehra, Kalsi (Uttarakhand), Dhauli & Jaugada (Odisha). Cover Dhamma policy, animal welfare, medical missions, religious tolerance.
Minor Rock Edicts	Several	Brahmi, Kharosthi	Bairat (Rajasthan), Maski (Karnataka -- only edict mentioning Ashoka by name!), Gujjarra (MP). Personal edicts about his own conversion and practice.

Major Pillar Edicts	7 in total	Brahmi	Delhi (Topra & Meerut pillars brought by Firuz Shah Tughlaq), Allahabad (Kosambi), Lauriya-Araraj, Lauriya-Nandangarh (Bihar), Rampurva. Cover detailed Dhamma code.
Minor Pillar Edicts	Several	Brahmi	Sanchi, Sarnath, Allahabad. Schism Edicts -- ordering expulsion of monks causing schism in Sangha.
Cave Inscriptions	3 caves	Brahmi	Barabar Hills (Bihar) -- 3 caves gifted to Ajivika monks. Shows religious tolerance.

Key Edict Content -- Most Tested in Exams

Edict	Content & Why It Matters
Rock Edict II	Medical missions established for humans and animals in Sri Lanka, Antiochus of Syria, Ptolemy of Egypt, Magas of Cyrene, Alexander of Epirus. Proves Mauryan international diplomatic reach.
Rock Edict XII	Religious tolerance -- 'growth of essentials of all religions'. Ashoka respects all sects.
Rock Edict XIII	The Kalinga edict -- most personal and emotional. Describes the devastation of Kalinga war and Ashoka's remorse. Most cited in all exams.
Lumbini Pillar Edict	Confirms Lumbini as Buddha's birthplace. Exempted from tax -- reduced to 1/8th of produce. Most important for identifying Buddha's birthplace historically.
Sarnath Pillar / Schism Edict	Orders that monks causing schism in the Buddhist Sangha be expelled. The Sarnath pillar has four back-to-back lions -- adopted as the National Emblem of India.
Maski Minor Rock Edict	Only edict that mentions 'Ashoka' by name. All others use 'Priyadarshi' (beloved of the gods/Devanampiya). KEY exam fact.

*The Sarnath Lion Capital (4 lions back-to-back on Ashoka Pillar at Sarnath):
Adopted as India's National Emblem in 1950.
The Ashoka Chakra (wheel) from this pillar appears on the Indian national flag.
Script on most edicts: Brahmi (deciphered by James Prinsep in 1837).*

Chapter 8 -- Mauryan Administration: Governing 1.5 Million sq km

How do you govern the largest empire in Indian history with no internet, no trains, and no printing press? The Mauryas developed a layered administrative system of breathtaking sophistication -- part described in Megasthenes' Indica, part in Kautilya's Arthashastra, and part visible in Ashoka's edicts. Every layer of this system has been tested in government exams.

Level	Unit	Head/Officer	Details
Central	Empire	Emperor (Raja/Samrat)	Advised by a council of ministers (Mantriparishad). Amatya = senior minister. Court at Pataliputra described by Megasthenes as magnificent.
Provincial	Province (Chakra)	Viceroy (Kumara -- usually a prince)	5 major provinces: Uttarapatha (NW, capital Taxila), Avantipatha (W, capital Ujjain), Prachya (E, capital Pataliputra), Dakshinapatha (S, capital Suvarnagiri), Kalinga (E coast, added by Ashoka).
District	Ahara/Vishaya	Pradeshika / Sthanika	Revenue collection and maintenance of law and order at district level.
Village	Grama	Gramika (village head)	Basic administrative unit. Gramika collected taxes and maintained village records.
City	Nagara	Nagaraka (city superintendent)	Pataliputra had a 30-member city council with 6 committees of 5 each (Megasthenes): industry, foreigners, births/deaths, trade, manufactures, tax on goods sold.
Special: Rajjukas	Rural areas	Rajjukas	Created by Ashoka -- empowered to reward and punish independently. Measured land and assessed taxes. Shows Ashoka's effort to decentralise justice.
Special: Dhamma Mahamattas	Empire-wide	Dhamma Officers	Created by Ashoka (13th year of reign) -- unique Mauryan innovation. Spread Dhamma, care for the poor, visit prisons, ensure religious tolerance.

Espionage System (Gudhapurusha / Guptachar)

The Arthashastra devotes an enormous section to espionage. The Mauryan spy system was one of the ancient world's most elaborate intelligence networks.

Spy Type	Role
Samstha (Stationary)	Fixed in one place -- in courts, trade guilds, villages. Monitored specific people or locations.
Sanchari (Roaming)	Mobile agents who moved between cities and provinces gathering intelligence.
Grihapatika	Disguised as householders -- long-term deep cover agents embedded in communities.
Vaidehaka	Disguised as merchants -- gathered commercial and political intelligence through trade networks.

Tapasa	Disguised as ascetics/monks -- had access to all places including forests and enemy kingdoms.
Vishakanya (Poison Girls)	Women trained from childhood with poison -- used for political assassinations. Among the most chilling innovations in the Arthashastra.

Chapter 9 -- Mauryan Economy, Society and Art

The Mauryan period was India's first great age of economic integration. A single political authority, standardised weights and measures, a network of roads, and a disciplined administrative apparatus enabled trade on a scale India had not seen since the Harappans. This wealth funded not just the army but a flourishing of art and architecture that produced some of India's most enduring symbols.

Domain	Key Facts
Agriculture	State-owned and private land both existed. Sitadhyaksha (superintendent of agriculture) oversaw crown lands. Irrigation works (Setu) were state-built. Sudarsana Lake at Girnar (Chandragupta era) -- one of ancient India's great irrigation works.
Trade & Commerce	Grand Trunk Road (Uttarapatha) from Taxila to Pataliputra. Internal trade thriving. External: sea trade with Sri Lanka, SE Asia, Persia, Arabia, Egypt. Merchants (Shreshthis) were wealthy and influential.
Currency	Punch-marked silver coins (Karshapana) -- most common. Copper coins also used. First systematically standardised coinage in India.
State industries	State monopolies: mining (Akaradhyaksha), textiles (Sautradhyaksha), shipbuilding (Navadhyaksha), gambling. Arthashastra lists 27 categories of superintendents.
Social structure	Megasthenes noted 7 castes (not the Vedic 4) -- philosophers, farmers, herdsman, artisans, soldiers, overseers, councillors. Slavery existed but was relatively mild compared to Rome/Greece.
Architecture	Shift from wood to stone. Pataliputra palace (wooden, described by Megasthenes as surpassing Susa and Persepolis). Ashoka's stone pillars, stupas (Sanchi Stupa begun by Ashoka), rock-cut caves (Barabar Hills).
Ashoka Pillars	Monolithic sandstone pillars (single stone, not assembled). Polished by Mauryan Chunar craftsmen. Capital animals: Lion (Sarnath, Vaishali), Bull (Rampurva), Elephant (Sankasia), Horse (Rampurva). Sarnath capital = National Emblem.
Mauryan art style	'Mauryan polish' -- highly reflective polish on stone pillars and sculptures, technically unmatched. Source: Arthashastra's Silpashastra (treatise on arts).

Chapter 10 -- Post-Mauryan Fragmentation: Sungas, Kanvas, Satavahanas

Ashoka died in 232 BCE. Within 50 years, his empire had collapsed. What followed was not a single successor but a mosaic of regional powers, each claiming legitimacy from the Mauryan legacy while fighting over its fragments. Three dynasties -- the Sungas, Kanvas, and Satavahanas -- define the post-Mauryan period and appear regularly in government exam questions.

Why Did the Maurya Empire Fall? -- Exam Theories

Theory / Factor	Explanation	Historian / Source
Weak successors	After Ashoka, 6 emperors in 50 years -- most ineffective. No strong central authority.	General consensus
Ashoka's pacifism weakened the army	Non-violence policy reduced military readiness; army became under-used and demoralised.	H.C. Raychaudhuri
Financial strain	Enormous welfare expenditure by Ashoka (roads, hospitals, missions) drained the treasury.	D.D. Kosambi
Brahminical reaction	Ashoka's support for Buddhism and ban on animal sacrifice alienated the Brahmin community -- Pushyamitra Sunga (a Brahmin) overthrew the last Maurya.	Romila Thapar
Provincial autonomy	Distant provinces began asserting independence -- Kalinga, Andhra, Bactrian Greeks in NW.	General consensus

The Three Successor Dynasties

Dynasty	Period	Founder & Origin	Key Facts
Sunga Dynasty	<i>185-73 BCE</i>	Pushyamitra Sunga -- Mauryan army general (Brahmin). Assassinated last Maurya emperor Brihadratha.	Brahminical revival: horse sacrifice (Ashvamedha) revived. Anti-Buddhist (persecuted Buddhist monks per some sources). Capital: Pataliputra. Art: Sanchi Stupa gateways (toranas) built. Vidisa (Besnagar) became important. Defeated Bactrian Greek invasion under Demetrius.
Kanva Dynasty	<i>73-28 BCE</i>	Vasudeva Kanva -- minister of last Sunga king. Overthrew the Sungas.	Short-lived (only 4 kings in 45 years). Brahminical but politically weak. Confined to Magadha region. Overthrown by Satavahanas from the Deccan.
Satavahana Dynasty	<i>1st c BCE - 3rd c CE</i>	Simuka Satavahana (also called Sindhuka). Originated from Andhra/Deccan region.	Most important post-Mauryan dynasty. Also called Andhra dynasty. Capital: Pratishthana (Paithan, Maharashtra). Rulers used title 'Dakshinapatha-pati'. Gautamiputra Satakarni (greatest ruler) defeated Kushanas, Sakas, and Pahlavas. Strong cultural patrons -- Prakrit literature, Buddhist art (Amaravati, Nagarjunakonda stupas). Used both Sanskrit and Prakrit.

*Gautamiputra Satakarni (Satavahana) -- most important post-Mauryan king:
 Called 'Ekabrahmana' (one true Brahmin) and 'Destroyer of Sakas, Pahlavas, and Yavanas'.
 His mother Gautami Balashri's inscription (Nasik) is our main source for his reign.
 He reunified most of peninsular India after the Saka invasion.*

Other Important Post-Mauryan Powers

Power	Region	Key Significance
Indo-Greeks (Bactrian Greeks)	<i>NW India (Punjab, Sindh)</i>	Menander (Milinda) -- greatest Indo-Greek king. Converted to Buddhism (Milindapanha records his dialogue with monk Nagasena). Introduced bilingual coins (Greek + Kharosthi). Gandhara art fusion began.
Shakas (Scythians)	<i>NW + Western India</i>	Rudradaman I (Shaka king) -- earliest Sanskrit prose inscription (Junagarh/Girnar, 150 CE). Repaired Sudarshana Lake. Defeated Satavahanas twice.
Pahlavas (Parthians)	<i>NW India</i>	Gondophernes -- ruled when St. Thomas (apostle) reportedly visited India. Minor power, soon displaced by Kushanas.
Kushanas	<i>NW + N India</i>	Kanishka I -- greatest Kushana emperor. 4th Buddhist Council. Patronised Mahayana Buddhism, Gandhara art, Mathura art school. Silk Route control. Will be covered in detail in Unit 4.

EXAM RADAR -- Must-Know Facts

- * Chandragupta Maurya founded the Maurya dynasty in 321 BCE by defeating Dhana Nanda (last Nanda king).
- * Chanakya's three names: Kautilya (most common), Chanakya, Vishnugupta.
- * Arthashastra was rediscovered in 1905 by R. Shamasastri at the Oriental Research Institute, Mysore.
- * Seleucid Treaty (305 BCE): Chandragupta got Afghanistan/Balochistan; gave 500 war elephants.
- * Megasthenes (Greek ambassador of Seleucus) visited Chandragupta's court; wrote 'Indica'.
- * Deimachus (Greek ambassador) visited BINDUSARA's court -- not Chandragupta's.
- * Bindusara is called 'Amitrochates' (Amitraghata = slayer of enemies) by Greek sources.
- * Kalinga War: 261 BCE, Rock Edict XIII -- 100,000 killed, 150,000 deported. Ashoka's transformation.
- * Dhamma is NOT the same as Buddhism -- it is a universal moral code for all religions.
- * Ashoka's edicts: 14 Major Rock Edicts + 7 Major Pillar Edicts + Minor Edicts + Cave inscriptions.
- * Maski Minor Rock Edict (Karnataka) is the ONLY edict mentioning Ashoka by name.
- * All other edicts use 'Devanampiya Piyadasi' (Beloved of Gods, of pleasing appearance).
- * Brahmi script was deciphered by James Prinsep in 1837 -- this unlocked Ashokan edicts.
- * Sarnath Lion Capital (4 lions) = India's National Emblem. Ashoka Chakra = on national flag.
- * Third Buddhist Council: 250 BCE, Pataliputra, patron Ashoka, president Moggaliputta Tissa.

- * Ashoka sent missionaries: Son Mahinda + daughter Sanghamitra to Sri Lanka with a Bodhi tree sapling.
- * Pataliputra city council: 30 members, 6 committees of 5 each (per Megasthenes' Indica).
- * Post-Mauryan order: Sunga (185-73 BCE) -> Kanva (73-28 BCE) -> Satavahana dominates Deccan.
- * Pushyamitra Sunga was a BRAHMIN army general who assassinated the last Maurya (Brihadratha).
- * Gautamiputra Satakarni = greatest Satavahana ruler; his exploits known from Nasik inscription.
- * Chandragupta Maurya converted to Jainism and died at Shravanabelagola (Karnataka) by Sallekhana.
- * 5 major Mauryan provinces: Uttarapatha (Taxila), Avantipatha (Ujjain), Prachya (Pataliputra), Dakshinapatha (Suvarnagiri), Kalinga.

Quick Revision -- 5-Minute Recap Before the Exam

Chandragupta	321 BCE, defeated Dhana Nanda. Seleucid War (305 BCE) -- got Afghanistan. Megasthenes at court. Converted to Jainism, died at Shravanabelagola.
Chanakya/Arthashastra	3 names: Kautilya, Chanakya, Vishnugupta. Arthashastra: Saptanga, Mandala theory, Shadgunya, espionage. Rediscovered 1905 by Shamasastri.
Bindusara	Called Amitrochates. Expanded south into Deccan. Greek ambassador Deimachus at his court. Ashoka served as his viceroy.
Kalinga War	261 BCE: 100,000 killed, 150,000 deported. Rock Edict XIII. Ashoka's moral transformation. Never waged war again.
Ashoka's Dhamma	Universal moral code -- NOT just Buddhism. Ahimsa, religious tolerance, welfare works, Dhamma Mahamattas, Dhamma Yatras.
Ashoka's Edicts	14 Major Rock + 7 Major Pillar + Minor. Brahmi script (Prinsep 1837). Maski Edict = only one with name 'Ashoka'. RE XIII = Kalinga.
Mauryan Admin	Emperor -> Viceroy (Kumara) -> Pradeshika -> Gramika. 5 provinces. Rajjukas (Ashoka). Dhamma Mahamattas (Ashoka). Spy network.
Post-Mauryan	Sunga (Brahmin revival, Pushyamitra) -> Kanva (weak, 4 kings) -> Satavahana (Deccan, Gautamiputra Satakarni, Amaravati). Kushanas/Shakas/Indo-Greeks in NW.